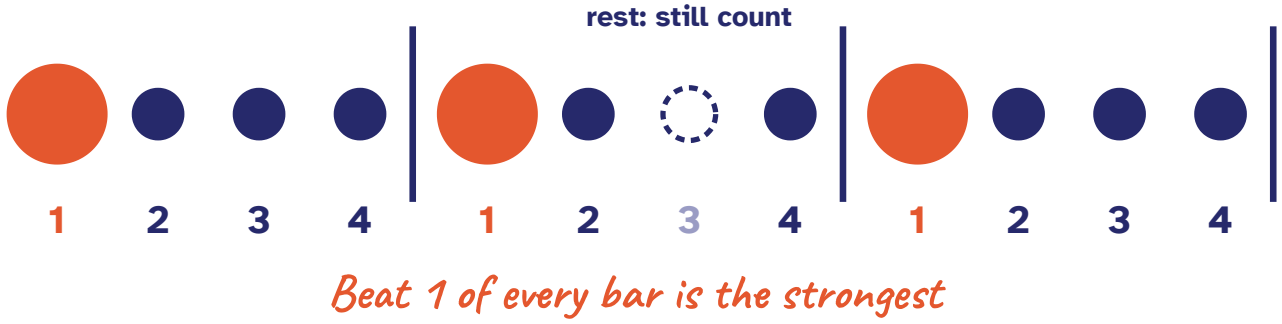
PART II · TIME · 1

Pulse, tempo and the bar

Put your hand on your heart: that steady beat is a **pulse**, and almost every piece has one. Its speed is the **tempo**. Beats travel in groups called **bars**, and beat 1 is the strongest.

THE SECRET

The beat never stops, not even in a rest. Feel it before you play.



Beat 1 of every bar is the strongest

Tempo

Tempo is measured in beats per minute. A **metronome mark** at the top of the music shows it: ♩ **= 60** means 60 crotchet beats a minute, one beat a second. ♩ **= 120** is twice as fast. Tempo words such as *Andante* and *Allegro* come with Expression, later in the book.

Strong and weak beats

BEATS	PATTERN	FEELS LIKE
2	**Strong** weak	a march
3	**Strong** weak weak	a waltz
4	**Strong** weak **medium** weak	most songs

Bars and bar lines

SIGN	NAME	MEANING
𝄀	bar line	divides the music into bars
𝄁	double bar line	marks the end of a section, or a change of key, time signature or tempo
𝄂	final bar line	marks the end of the piece
𝄆 𝄇	repeat signs	play the passage between them again; if there is no start sign, go back to the beginning

PART II · TIME · 1 · CONTINUED

The beat in tunes you know

TUNE	BEATS IN A BAR	PATTERN
Twinkle, Twinkle, Little Star	4	**Strong** weak **medium** weak
Happy Birthday	3	**Strong** weak weak
The Blue Danube (a waltz)	3	**Strong** weak weak
Radetzky March	2	**Strong** weak

Counting

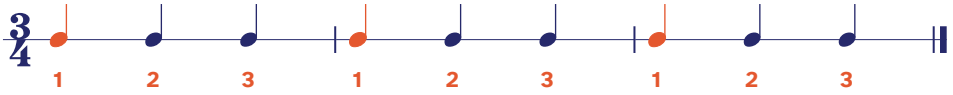


Three bars of 3/4. Every beat is counted, even inside a long note: the red number is where you play, the grey numbers are the beats you hold.

Count aloud at one speed, a little louder on beat 1. With a metronome, start slower than you think and speed up only when the passage is steady.

EXAMPLE 1

Is this a march or a waltz?

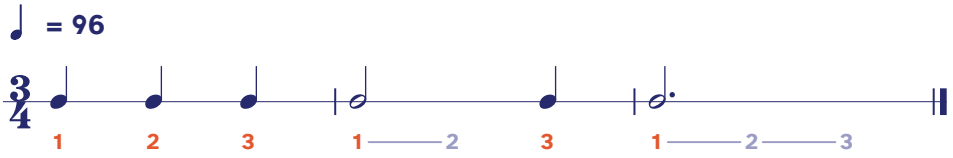


1. **Tap a steady beat** as you clap or listen.
2. **Find the strong one:** the red beats feel heavier.
3. **Count the gap** between strong beats: 1 2 3, 1 2 3.

Groups of three: a **waltz**, in 3/4. Groups of two would be a march.

EXAMPLE 2

Feel the beat before you play



1. **Read the mark:** ♩ = 96, 96 crotchet beats a minute.
2. **Listen first:** set the metronome and let one full bar go by, counting “1 2 3” in your head.
3. **Step in** on the next beat 1, the way you step onto a moving escalator.

The first note lands **on the beat**, not a guess.

PART II · TIME · 1 · CONTINUED

GAME

How many beats in a bar?



The big dot is the strong beat. Count the beats in each bar: 2, 3 or 4?

Answer: 1 three (a waltz) · 2 four · 3 two (a march) · 4 three, twice.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Hand on your heart. Tap the beat.

Say “1 2 3 4” with your taps, 1 a little louder. Keep going for ten seconds without slowing down.
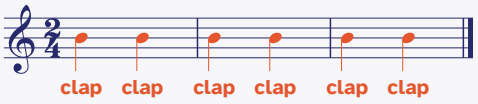
HOW TO

Find the beat of a new piece

1. **Read the time signature:** how many beats in each bar.
2. **Tap the beat** on your knee before you play, counting one bar aloud.
3. **Start slower** than the marked speed, and keep it steady to the end.

YOU KNOW THIS

Radetzky March (Johann Strauss I)



At the New Year concert the audience claps along on **every beat**. That steady clap is the pulse; the orchestra’s tune moves freely over it.

Try it. Put on any march and clap only the beat, not the tune.

THINK OF IT The beat is the stage and the notes are the actors: the stage is there before anyone walks on. So step in the way you step onto an escalator or take a plate off a sushi train: watch it move for a bar, then join in.

TRAP

- × Speeding up in easy bars and slowing in hard ones: the pulse never changes.
- × Counting only the notes you play: the beat goes on through long notes and rests.

SEE ALSO
Time signatures p. 56 · Tempo words: Expression (later)

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Level 0 · Pulse · Online: Metronome